

we'd watch a movie and I'd go to bed early. I did not drink coffee or soda. I did not drink alcohol. I cried all the time. I slowly got better.

But I was furious. I was desperate to get back to NYC where I was still paying the \$800 rent on my bedroom in Harlem. I wasn't spending anything in Florida, but I also hated the idea of my room sitting empty while I paid for it. It took a month in Florida for me to regain my strength, and I convinced my parents to let me go back to the city to attend a fancy dinner party I'd been looking forward to. My priorities were still the same as they'd ever been. I decided I couldn't afford new meds, but that it was fine. I was better now. A year later, I moved to LA. My job provided health insurance, and since I was stressed about the move, I went back on meds: Zoloft and Klonopin. I thought I was so responsible. I thought everything was stable.

So when I had another breakdown in 2016 and a psychiatrist in LA asked if I'd ever been diagnosed with bipolar II, I said yes. I had been. Multiple times.

If I was going to really fix my financial troubles, then I had to admit there were other things at play beyond irresponsibility and youthful ignorance. I could learn about taxes and individual retirement accounts, and I could work really hard to get out of debt, but in the end, I was always one mental lapse away from destroying my credit score. The meds for depression weren't fixing the real problem. Eight years after my first breakdown, I finally started on Lamictal specifically for bipolar disorder, and gradually I got a handle on my brain.



I'm not saying medication is the answer for everyone. I'm not a doctor, and I'm not you. Also, my meds are now covered by insurance. My therapist costs me \$125 a session and my psychiatrist costs me \$225 every two months, but it's money I have now and I'm willing to spend on myself. I know not everyone is in that position. But even more than the meds and doctors, what saved me from financial ruin was realizing that there were other psychological factors that contributed to my overspending.

Julie Fast, a writer, educator, and expert on bipolar disorder, had a long road to diagnosis too. In 1995, she was 31 years old when she was told she had bipolar